

3C STRATEGIC APPROACH

A Context-Focused Approach to Organizational Attention, Insight, and Action

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1. THE 3C IDENTITY

3C is a context-focused strategic approach that directs organizational attention toward the Source, Dependency, or Constraint most relevant to understanding and changing the conditions affecting effective application and execution.

3C is concerned primarily with **where organizational attention should be directed before deciding what should be changed.**

Its foundational premise is:

Context determines focus.

Its intellectual contribution is:

Context changes the question. Changed questions create or reveal better insight.

3C therefore begins with **context**, not intervention, optimization, or solution selection.

It asks organizations to examine the condition surrounding an observed problem before deciding how that problem should be addressed.

2. 3C IN ONE SENTENCE

3C directs organizational attention toward the Source, Dependency, or Constraint most relevant to understanding and changing the conditions affecting effective application and execution.

3. FOUNDATIONAL DISTINCTION

Traditional management often begins with the visible activity:

How can we do this work better?

3C begins one level earlier:

What context is creating or sustaining this condition?

The same visible problem may arise from fundamentally different conditions.

For example:

- **Rework** may require attention to its **Source**.
- **Slow action** may require attention to a **Dependency**.
- **A bottleneck** may require attention to a **Constraint**.
- **Repeated workload** may require attention to the underlying **Source** generating it.

Therefore:

The activity does not determine the question. The context determines the question.

This is the foundational shift of 3C.

4. CORE PROPOSITION

Organizations frequently manage visible consequences without examining the conditions that create or sustain them.

This can produce:

- repeated symptoms,
- recurring demand,
- escalation,
- approvals,
- coordination burden,
- rework,
- slow decisions,
- unused or restricted capability,
- operational friction,
- capacity consumption without proportional value.

3C redirects attention from the visible condition toward the context that may be generating, sustaining, depending upon, or restricting it.

Its core logic is:

**CONTEXT → FOCUS → QUESTION → INSIGHT → ATTENTION → ACTION → CONDITION
CHANGE → CAPACITY EFFECT → EFFECTIVE APPLICATION → EXECUTION**

3C operates primarily at the **attention and inquiry stage**.

It does not prescribe a universal intervention.

5. THE THREE CONTEXTS

3C identifies three primary contextual dimensions:

SOURCE · DEPENDENCY · CONSTRAINT

These are not sequential steps. They are alternative or overlapping contexts through which an organizational condition may be examined.

5.1 SOURCE

Definition

Source is the condition generating or repeatedly sustaining the observed outcome.

The Source context asks:

Why does this keep arising?

Typical signals include:

- recurring errors,
- repeated rework,
- recurring demand,
- repeated escalation,
- recurring exceptions,
- repeated complaints,
- repeated corrective activity.

The purpose is to identify what is generating or sustaining the condition.

A Source is **not automatically a defect to eliminate**.

The source may be necessary, legitimate, structural, customer-driven, regulatory, strategic, or otherwise justified.

Response orientation

Source-oriented inquiry may lead toward **continuous improvement**, corrective action, redesign, prevention, or other appropriate responses.

Continuous Improvement is **not the name of the C**.

5.2 DEPENDENCY

Definition

Dependency is a condition in which action, decision, progress, or execution depends upon another person, function, approval, system, resource, or condition.

The Dependency context asks:

Why does action depend on someone or something else?

Typical signals include:

- approvals,
- handoffs,
- escalation dependency,
- waiting,
- coordination requirements,
- intervention by another function,
- restricted decision authority,
- dependence on information or resources.

The purpose is not to assume that dependency is bad.

The inquiry determines whether the dependency is:

- necessary,
- appropriate,
- enabling,
- protective,
- temporary,
- unnecessarily restrictive,
- structurally created,

- or otherwise affecting effective application.

Response orientation

Dependency-oriented inquiry may lead toward **continuous empowerment**, redesign of decision rights, interface redesign, clarification of ownership, or other appropriate responses.

Continuous Empowerment is **not the name of the C**.

5.3 CONSTRAINT

Definition

Constraint is a condition restricting or limiting movement, application, decision, flow, or execution.

The Constraint context asks:

What is preventing effective action?

Typical signals include:

- bottlenecks,
- restrictive policies,
- unavailable resources,
- system limitations,
- conflicting requirements,
- access restrictions,
- process restrictions,
- organizational barriers.

The purpose is to identify the relevant constraint and determine what, if anything, can appropriately change.

Response orientation

Constraint-oriented inquiry may lead toward **continuous constraint reduction**, constraint management, resource changes, policy changes, sequencing changes, or other appropriate interventions.

Continuous Constraint Reduction is **not the name of the C**.

6. THE THREE CONTEXTS ARE NOT STAGES

Source, Dependency, and Constraint are **contexts for attention**, not sequential stages.

A single condition may involve:

- one context,
- two contexts,
- or all three.

For example, a repeated approval requirement may simultaneously be:

- a **Dependency**, because action depends on approval;
- a **Source**, if the approval requirement repeatedly generates workload or delay;
- a **Constraint**, if the approval restricts timely action.

Therefore:

3C is not a three-step process.

It is a **context-selection and attention mechanism**.

The purpose is to determine which contextual dimension—or combination of dimensions—deserves attention before an intervention is selected.

7. CONTEXT DETERMINES QUESTION

The same observed condition can produce different questions depending on the context selected.

Observed condition	Source question	Dependency question	Constraint question
Rework	What keeps creating rework?	Who must repeatedly resolve it?	What prevents first-time-right execution?
Approval	Why is approval required?	Why does action depend on approval?	What does approval prevent?
Escalation	What keeps creating escalation?	Why does the issue require escalation?	What prevents resolution at source?
Coordination	Why is coordination repeatedly required?	Why does progress depend on coordination?	What prevents independent flow?
Bottleneck	What keeps creating the bottleneck?	Who or what does flow depend on?	What is restricting flow?
Workload	What keeps generating the workload?	What creates dependency on additional intervention?	What prevents efficient completion?

Observed condition	Source question	Dependency question	Constraint question
Slow response	What keeps causing the delay?	What does the response depend on?	What prevents timely action?

The principle is:

Do not begin with the activity. Begin with the context.

8. QUESTION TRANSFORMATIONS

3C changes the question before attempting to change the condition.

Conventional question	3C question
How can we perform repeated work faster?	Why does this work keep arising?
How can we reduce rework?	What keeps creating rework?
How can we process approvals faster?	Why is approval required?
How can we handle escalation better?	Why is escalation necessary?
How can we coordinate better?	Why is coordination repeatedly required?
How can we work around the bottleneck?	What is restricting flow?
How can we manage workload better?	What keeps generating workload?
How can we automate the activity?	Should the activity exist in its current form?
How can we respond faster?	What prevents timely action?

This produces the principle:

Question before optimization.

Optimization should follow understanding, not replace it.

9. 3C DIAGNOSTIC INQUIRY

3C separates observation, interpretation, inquiry, and intervention.

The diagnostic logic is:

What do we observe?



What context best explains it?



What does that context make visible?



What question does it reveal?



What insight does the question produce?



What deserves attention?

This separation helps prevent organizations from moving directly from symptom to solution.

3C therefore distinguishes:

Observation ≠ Interpretation ≠ Question ≠ Intervention

10. 3C IN PRACTICE

Example 1 — Repeated Approvals

Observation:

A routine activity repeatedly requires approval.

A Dependency question asks:

Why does action depend on approval?

Possible explanations may include:

- unclear decision rights,
- historical controls,
- risk assumptions,
- insufficient capability,
- regulatory requirements,
- legitimate governance,
- organizational design.

3C does not assume the approval should be removed.

It first determines the context.

Example 2 — Billing Errors

Observation:

Billing errors recur.

A Source question asks:

What keeps creating the billing errors?

Possible sources may include:

- incorrect source data,
- unclear ownership,
- system configuration,
- incomplete information,
- inconsistent rules,
- upstream process conditions.

The objective is not merely to correct individual errors but to understand the condition sustaining them.

Example 3 — Bottleneck

Observation:

Work accumulates at a particular point.

A Constraint question asks:

What is restricting flow?

Possible explanations include:

- insufficient capacity,
- sequencing,
- policy,
- system limitation,
- decision rights,
- resource availability,
- dependency.

The observed bottleneck does not itself prove that capacity is the cause.

Example 4 — Excessive Coordination

Observation:

Teams spend substantial time coordinating.

A combined 3C inquiry may ask:

- **Source:** Why is coordination repeatedly required?
- **Dependency:** Why does progress depend on these interactions?
- **Constraint:** What prevents independent flow?

Possible conditions include:

- fragmented ownership,
 - unclear interfaces,
 - duplicated responsibilities,
 - information gaps,
 - unnecessary dependency,
 - structural constraints.
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11. WHAT 3C SEES

3C treats the following as **signals requiring contextual inquiry**, not automatic evidence of waste or failure:

- recurring demand,
- friction,
- rework,
- unnecessary or excessive dependency,
- repeated intervention,
- escalation,
- coordination burden,
- bottlenecks,
- restrictions,
- slow action,
- unused capability,
- inaccessible capability,
- restricted decision rights,
- capacity consumption without proportional value.

The key principle is:

A signal is not a diagnosis.

The observed condition must be contextualized before a conclusion is drawn.

12. 3C AND ORGANIZATIONAL CAPACITY

Within HEE:

Capability = Potential.

Capacity = Ability to mobilize and apply potential.

Organizational conditions can consume or restrict usable capacity through:

- unnecessary activity,
- repeated work,
- waiting,
- dependency,
- coordination,
- intervention,
- restricted decision rights,
- system limitations,
- organizational barriers.

3C asks:

What condition is affecting the organization's ability to apply its available capacity effectively?

However, 3C does not itself:

- recover Human Energy,
- develop capability,
- connect capability,
- enable application,
- manage execution.

Its role is to identify the contextual conditions that deserve attention.

13. 3C AND HUMAN ENERGY

Conditions examined through 3C can contribute to Human Energy consumption or interference.

Examples include:

- repeated rework,
- unnecessary approvals,

- escalation,
- excessive coordination,
- repeated intervention,
- waiting,
- avoidable dependency,
- restrictive conditions.

3C can therefore help identify conditions associated with Human Energy loss.

But:

3C does not recover Human Energy.

Human Energy recovery remains within the appropriate HEE mechanisms, particularly Human Energy Recovery.

3C identifies the context; other mechanisms act on the condition where appropriate.

14. 3C, EX, CX, SLA AND XLA

Employee Experience

Organizational conditions can affect EX through:

- friction,
- waiting,
- rework,
- dependency,
- unnecessary intervention,
- restricted autonomy,
- unclear decision rights.

3C examines the organizational context behind these conditions.

Customer Experience

CX may reveal symptoms of internal conditions through:

- delays,
- errors,
- effort,
- slow resolution,
- inconsistent service.

However:

Negative CX does not by itself prove a specific internal 3C condition.

The internal context still requires examination.

SLA

A Service Level Agreement establishes service-performance commitments.

XLA

An Experience Level Agreement focuses on customer or user experience.

3C examines the organizational context affecting the ability to sustain both.

SLA protects service performance. XLA protects customer/user experience. 3C examines organizational context affecting the ability to sustain both.

15. 3C AND ORGANIZATIONAL GROWTH

Organizational growth commonly adds:

- functions,
- systems,
- decisions,
- interfaces,
- dependencies,
- specialized capabilities,
- handoffs,
- coordination,
- priorities.

As complexity increases, the challenge can shift from simply managing more activity toward understanding the contexts creating and sustaining that complexity.

Therefore:

From managing more complexity → to understanding contexts creating complexity.

Growth itself is not the problem.

The requirement is that organizational attention evolves with organizational complexity.

16. 3C AND THE HEE ECOSYSTEM

3C occupies a specific position within the HEE ecosystem.

Component	Primary role
HEE	Foundational theory and economic lens
OEOS/OOS	Management and operating architecture
OSF	Reduces unnecessary recurring operational demand
3C	Directs strategic attention through context
5R	Determines tactical disposition
HEEn	Enables effective application
EES	Manages execution
HEMS	Manages Human Energy and organizational capacity
HERF	Recovers Human Energy
HEDP	Develops capability

The ecosystem logic is:

HEE explains. OEOS/OOS orchestrates. OSF reduces unnecessary demand. 3C directs attention. 5R determines disposition. HEEn enables application. EES manages execution.

These are complementary roles, not necessarily a rigid sequence.

17. 3C AND OSF

3C and OSF address related but distinct questions.

3C asks:

What context should receive attention?

OSF asks:

Should this recurring operational demand exist at all?

3C contextualizes the demand.

OSF determines whether unnecessary recurring demand should be challenged.

Therefore:

3C contextualizes demand; OSF challenges unnecessary demand.

3C does not automatically classify observed demand as unnecessary.

18. 3C → 5R

The relationship between 3C and 5R is:

3C = WHERE
5R = HOW

3C identifies the context requiring attention.

5R determines the potential disposition:

REMOVE → REDUCE → REPLACE → RE-ENGINEER → RETAIN

The relationship is complementary.

Not every 3C case requires 5R.

Not every 5R intervention requires prior 3C.

5R is therefore not a mandatory downstream stage of 3C.

19. 3C AND CONDITION CHANGE

3C improves the quality of attention so that action can be directed toward relevant conditions.

Its core relationship is:

Context → Question → Insight → Attention → Condition Change

Condition change may subsequently affect:

Capacity → Effective Application → Execution → Sustainable Execution Capacity → Sustainable Business Value

But 3C does not guarantee those outcomes.

It creates the possibility for better-directed action.

20. VALUE CREATION LOGIC

3C does not directly create business value.

Its contribution is upstream.

The conceptual value pathway is:

**CONTEXT → QUESTION → INSIGHT → ATTENTION → CONDITION CHANGE → CAPACITY
EFFECT → EFFECTIVE APPLICATION → EXECUTION → SUSTAINED EXECUTION CAPACITY →
SUSTAINABLE BUSINESS VALUE**

Therefore:

3C creates possibility before it creates performance.

Its value lies in improving the quality and direction of organizational attention before resources are committed to intervention.

21. CORE PRINCIPLES

Principle 1 — Context Before Intervention

Understand the context before selecting the intervention.

Principle 2 — Question Before Optimization

Ask the right question before attempting to optimize the activity.

Principle 3 — Source Before Symptom

Examine what generates or sustains the condition.

Principle 4 — Dependency Before Escalation

Understand why action depends on another person, function, system, or condition before assuming escalation is required.

Principle 5 — Constraint Before Blame

Examine what restricts action before attributing failure to individuals.

Principle 6 — Insight Before Action

Do not confuse observation with understanding.

Principle 7 — Change Conditions, Not Just Consequences

Where appropriate, act on the condition producing or sustaining the observed outcome.

Principle 8 — Necessary Conditions Must Remain

Do not eliminate a condition merely because it consumes resources or creates effort.

Principle 9 — Capacity Effect Must Be Examined

Consider what a condition does to the organization's ability to apply capacity.

Principle 10 — Prevent Recurrence

Where appropriate, address the conditions that repeatedly recreate the same problem.

22. WHAT 3C DOES NOT ASSUME

3C does **not** assume that:

- all recurring work is unnecessary;
- all dependencies are bad;
- all constraints should be removed;
- all approvals are unnecessary;
- all coordination is waste;
- all escalation indicates failure;
- all intervention is harmful;
- all bottlenecks are capacity problems;
- all negative CX originates internally;
- autonomy is always desirable;
- every problem has one root cause;
- Source is always eliminable;
- every condition can or should be optimized.

This is important because 3C is a **contextual inquiry approach**, not an elimination philosophy.

23. MANAGEMENT LOGIC

The conceptual management logic is:

**CONTEXT → FOCUS → QUESTION → INSIGHT → ATTENTION → ACTION → CONDITION
CHANGE → CAPACITY EFFECT → APPLICATION → EXECUTION**

A practical expression is:

**LOOK → CONTEXTUALIZE → QUESTION → UNDERSTAND → FOCUS → CHANGE →
OBSERVE EFFECT → LEARN → ADAPT**

This is a practical logic, not a mandatory or rigid process.

24. LEADERSHIP DIAGNOSTIC TEST

A leader applying 3C can ask:

1. What are we observing?
2. What context are we looking at?
3. Which context appears primary?
4. What question does that context create?
5. What insight does the question reveal?
6. Where should attention go?
7. What condition should change?
8. What capacity effect might result?
9. What happens to effective application?
10. What happens to execution?
11. What did we learn?
12. What should we adapt?

The central leadership question is:

What context are we looking at—and what question does it make possible?

25. PRIORITIZATION

3C may use the following **shared ecosystem prioritization heuristic**:

Priority = Urgency × Interdependence × Value Impact

This is shared infrastructure across the HEE ecosystem, rather than a mathematical construct independently derived by 3C.

Within the heuristic, **Interdependence** refers to the magnitude or significance of relationships affecting movement, action, or outcomes.

It should not be interpreted as redefining **Dependency**, which remains one of the three canonical 3C contexts.

The distinction is deliberate:

Dependency = a 3C contextual dimension.

Interdependence = a shared prioritization dimension.

The heuristic is conceptual and directional, not a validated universal mathematical law.

26. MATURITY MODEL

3C can be understood conceptually through a **nine-level maturity progression**.

Level 1 — Reactive

“Fix what is happening.”

Attention is directed primarily toward visible problems and immediate consequences.

Level 2 — Aware

“This keeps happening.”

The organization recognizes recurrence.

Level 3 — Contextual

“What context is involved?”

Attention begins shifting from symptoms toward contextual conditions.

Level 4 — Questioning

“What question should we actually ask?”

The organization recognizes that the quality of the question influences the quality of the diagnosis.

Level 5 — Insight-Driven

“What does context reveal?”

Context is used to generate deeper understanding.

Level 6 — Strategic Attention

“Where should attention go?”

Attention becomes deliberately directed toward the most relevant contextual condition.

Level 7 — Preventive

“What should we change before recurrence?”

The organization increasingly addresses conditions before the same problem reappears.

Level 8 — Capacity-Directed

“What is this condition doing to our ability to apply capacity?”

The organization connects contextual conditions with organizational capacity and effective application.

Level 9 — Sustainable

“How do we continuously understand and improve conditions that sustain execution?”

Contextual inquiry becomes part of ongoing organizational learning and adaptation.

27. DIFFERENTIATION

3C differs from established management approaches not because it claims ownership of their underlying ideas, but because it assigns **Source, Dependency, and Constraint** a specific role as co-equal contextual dimensions for directing attention before intervention.

Approach	Primary starting point	3C distinction
Traditional Problem Solving	Problem	Asks what context determines the appropriate question
Process Improvement	Process	Does not assume the process itself is the correct unit of inquiry

Approach	Primary starting point	3C distinction
Lean / Waste Reduction	Waste / non-value activity	Does not assume observed activity is waste
Automation	Activity	Asks whether the activity should exist before automating it
Root Cause Analysis	Cause	Treats Source as one contextual dimension alongside Dependency and Constraint
Constraint Management / TOC	System constraint	Constraint is one of three 3C contexts, not the entire approach
Delegation / Empowerment	Decision authority	Examines Dependency before assuming empowerment is the answer
Strategic Planning	Objectives / strategic position	Focuses on organizational context affecting application and execution
HEE	Human Energy / organizational capacity	Provides a contextual attention lens within HEE
OSF	Unnecessary recurring operational demand	Contextualizes conditions; OSF determines whether demand should exist
5R	Disposition	3C determines where attention may belong; 5R determines disposition where applicable

The central distinction is:

3C does not begin by asking what to improve. It begins by understanding the context that determines what question should be asked.

28. 3C AND OPERATIONAL DEMAND

3C can be applied to recurring operational demand.

However, it does not automatically classify demand as unnecessary.

Demand may be:

- necessary,
- legally required,
- risk-related,
- customer-required,
- strategically important,
- value-creating,

- protective,
- or genuinely unnecessary.

3C asks what context is creating or sustaining the demand.

Where unnecessary recurring demand is confirmed, OSF and 5R may become relevant.

Therefore:

3C contextualizes demand; OSF challenges unnecessary demand.

29. 3C AND CAPABILITY

Within HEE:

Capability = Potential.

Capability may exist but remain:

- unused,
- inaccessible,
- disconnected,
- restricted,
- dependent,
- unsupported,
- or otherwise difficult to apply.

3C asks:

What context is affecting the non-application of available capability?

The answer may be:

- Source,
- Dependency,
- Constraint,
- or a combination.

3C does not itself develop or enable the capability.

30. 3C AND EFFECTIVE APPLICATION

Capability does not automatically become application.

The conceptual relationship is:

Capability → Application

But application is affected by organizational conditions.

3C therefore asks:

What context is affecting our ability to apply the capability?

That context may be a:

Source · Dependency · Constraint

or a combination of them.

The resulting intervention may belong to another HEE mechanism.

31. 3C AND OTHER HEE MECHANISMS

3C has a specific ownership boundary.

Mechanism / framework	Primary ownership
HEE	Economic theory and foundational logic
OEOS/OOS	Organizational operating architecture
OSF	Operational demand and silence
3C	Strategic contextual attention
5R	Tactical disposition
HEMS	Human Energy and capacity management
HERF	Human Energy recovery
HEDP	Capability development
HEEn	Organizational enablement
EES	Execution management

Therefore:

3C directs attention. It does not replace the mechanisms that act on what attention reveals.

32. RELATED WORK AND THEORETICAL POSITION

3C does not claim that examining sources, dependencies, or constraints is newly discovered.

Each of these orientations has established intellectual antecedents.

The contribution of 3C lies in **how these contextual dimensions are positioned and combined as parallel possibilities for organizational attention.**

32.1 Constraint — Theory of Constraints

The **Theory of Constraints (TOC)**, associated particularly with Eliyahu M. Goldratt, establishes the idea that system performance can be limited by constraints and that improvement should focus attention on the limiting constraint.

The classic TOC improvement logic includes identifying the constraint, exploiting it, subordinating other activity to it, elevating it where necessary, and repeating the cycle.

Constraint is therefore a direct and important antecedent to the 3C Constraint context.

3C does **not** claim to discover constraint management.

Its distinction is one of **scope and role.**

In 3C:

Constraint is one of three co-equal contextual dimensions.

TOC, by contrast, is a broader management philosophy and improvement cycle organized around system constraints.

3C asks:

What is restricting action or flow?

That question may lead to TOC, another constraint-management method, or another appropriate intervention.

3C does not replace TOC.

It prevents organizations from assuming that every condition should be examined exclusively through a constraint lens.

A single condition may be:

Source + Dependency + Constraint

at the same time.

32.2 Source — Root Cause Analysis

Root Cause Analysis and related causal-analysis methods establish the importance of examining what generates observed problems.

Ishikawa's cause-and-effect approach and subsequent methods such as the **5 Whys** represent established traditions of investigating causal conditions rather than merely treating symptoms.

3C Source shares this orientation.

However:

Source is not synonymous with “root cause.”

Source identifies the condition that generates or sustains an observed condition.

RCA represents a broader family of causal-analysis methods.

The distinction is that Source is one of three 3C contextual dimensions rather than the exclusive or dominant diagnostic lens.

A condition may have a Source while the more important organizational issue lies in a Dependency or Constraint.

32.3 Dependency — Critical Path and Dependency Analysis

Project scheduling and dependency-management traditions have long established the importance of understanding relationships among activities and the effects of dependencies on timing, sequencing, and performance.

Critical Path Method (CPM), developed through the work of Kelley and Walker, provides an important historical antecedent for formal attention to activity dependencies.

3C Dependency draws on the same fundamental concern:

Action can depend upon something else.

However, 3C applies the idea more broadly to organizational conditions such as:

- decisions,
- approvals,
- handoffs,
- capability access,
- information,
- resources,
- authority,
- systems,
- execution conditions.

CPM is primarily concerned with project activities, sequencing, and schedules.

3C is concerned with the broader organizational context in which dependency affects application and execution.

32.4 Theoretical Position

3C can therefore be positioned as:

A context-selection framework that draws on three established diagnostic traditions—constraint management, root cause analysis, and dependency analysis—and integrates them as three co-equal contextual dimensions for determining where organizational attention should go before selecting an intervention method.

Its distinctive contribution is **not any one of the three lenses individually.**

Each has a deeper literature and established methods.

The contribution is the disciplined treatment of:

Source · Dependency · Constraint

as parallel contextual possibilities before an organization defaults to a familiar diagnostic or intervention lens.

Canonical definitions

Source = what generates or sustains the condition.

Dependency = what the condition depends upon.

Constraint = what restricts or limits action or flow.

These are three contextual dimensions, not competing theories of causation.

A single condition may require one, two, or all three.

32.5 Theoretical Boundary

3C does not claim:

- originality of Root Cause Analysis;
- originality of dependency analysis;
- originality of constraint management;
- superiority over Theory of Constraints;
- replacement of RCA;
- replacement of CPM;
- replacement of established dependency-management methods.

Its narrower distinctive claim is:

3C provides a context-selection discipline for determining which established contextual lens should receive attention before an intervention is selected.

32.6 References

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33. RESEARCH POSITION

3C is a **conceptual strategic management framework**, not an empirically validated universal theory.

Its current claims are conceptual.

Future research may examine:

- construct validity;
- construct distinctiveness;
- reliability;
- diagnostic usefulness;

- practical applicability;
- interactions among Source, Dependency, and Constraint;
- relationships with organizational capacity;
- relationships with Human Energy;
- relationships with EX and CX;
- relationships with execution outcomes;
- measurement approaches;
- empirical validation.

Future research should determine:

1. whether the three dimensions are empirically distinguishable;
2. whether practitioners can reliably identify them;
3. whether context selection improves diagnostic quality;
4. whether improved contextual diagnosis improves intervention selection;
5. whether this produces measurable improvements in organizational outcomes.

34. CONCEPTUAL BOUNDARIES

3C is particularly useful where:

- a visible problem has multiple possible explanations;
- recurring conditions are being repeatedly managed;
- organizational attention is fragmented;
- symptoms are being treated repeatedly;
- dependencies are unclear;
- constraints are unclear;
- root-cause thinking alone may be insufficient;
- intervention appears premature;
- capability exists but is not being effectively applied.

3C is **not**:

- a replacement for operational management;
- a universal problem-solving method;
- an execution system;
- a Human Energy recovery system;
- a capability-development system;
- an enablement framework;
- an automatic performance-improvement mechanism;
- a replacement for TOC;
- a replacement for RCA;
- a replacement for project dependency methods.

Its role is:

35. QUICK REFERENCE

Identity

Context-focused strategic approach

Core premise

Context determines focus.

Core distinction

Context before intervention.

Three contexts

Source · Dependency · Constraint

Governing questions

Source

Why does this keep arising?

Dependency

Why does action depend on someone or something else?

Constraint

What is preventing effective action?

Strategic role

Direct attention.

Cognitive logic

Context → Focus → Question → Insight → Action

Condition logic

Action → Condition Change → Capacity Effect

Application logic

Capacity Effect → Effective Application → Execution

3C → 5R

WHERE → HOW

Value pathway

Condition Change → Capacity Effect → Application → Execution → Sustainable
Execution Capacity → Sustainable Business Value

HEE relationship

Contextual attention

Primary question

What context are we looking at?

Final question

What question does that context make possible?

36. SIMPLEST FORM

The simplest representation of 3C is:

CONTEXT → QUESTION → INSIGHT → ATTENTION → CHANGE → POSSIBILITY

3C changes the context of attention.

Changed context changes the question.

The changed question reveals or creates new insight.

Insight redirects attention.

Redirected attention enables more relevant condition change.

Condition change creates new possibilities for capacity and application.

Therefore:

3C changes where the organization looks before it decides what to change.

37. FINAL PRINCIPLE

Do not begin by asking what to improve. Begin by understanding the context that determines what question should be asked.

FINAL QUESTION

What context are we looking at—and what question does it make possible?

RELATED FRAMEWORKS

Human Energy Economics (HEE)

Foundational economic theory and lens.

Operational Silence Framework (OSF)

Reduces unnecessary recurring operational demand.

5R Cascade

Determines tactical disposition: Remove → Reduce → Replace → Re-engineer → Retain.

Human Energy Enablement (HEEn)

Addresses organizational conditions affecting effective application.

Execution Excellence System (EES)

Manages execution through FIND → FIX → CONTROL → ADAPT → GROW.

STATUS

Version 1.0 — Canonical Edition

The architecture of 3C is considered settled at this stage.

Future development should focus primarily on:

- application;
- research;
- measurement;
- empirical validation;
- case development;
- practical diagnostic tools.

Fundamental redesign is not currently required.

CREATOR

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LICENSE

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CLOSING

It changes where the organization looks before it decides what to change.

Context determines focus.

Context changes the question.

Better questions create better possibilities for action.